

GB

Advanced English Grammar

Formal & Advanced Structures · C1 to C2

The conditionals in full, inversion, the subjunctive, cleft sentences, participle clauses, the advanced passive and formal register — the high-level grammar expected in proficiency exams and formal written British English.

Conditionals & inversion

Subjunctive

Cleft & emphasis

Advanced passive

Formal register

Advanced English study pack

How to use this reference

At **C1–C2** the examiner looks for a *range* of complex structures used accurately and appropriately — not just correct sentences, but native-like control of emphasis, hypothesis and formal register. This pack gathers the structures that make the difference, grouped into ten themes.

How each entry works

Every entry gives the **name of the structure**, its **form** (in the grey pattern box, e.g.

Had + S + p.p., ... would have + p.p.), a short explanation and two example sentences. An italic gloss such as (= *If I had known*) shows the plain equivalent.

Register key: **formal** written/official English **literary** very formal or old-fashioned **BrE** especially British
spoken conversational

Study tip: don't just recognise these — *produce* them. Take a plain sentence (*If it hadn't rained, we'd have gone*) and rewrite it three ways: inversion (*Had it not rained...*), *but for* (*But for the rain...*), and a cleft (*It was the rain that stopped us*). The ability to paraphrase one idea in several registers is exactly what C2 rewards.

1 · The conditional system

2 · Beyond "if": alternatives

3 · Conditional inversion

4 · Inversion after negatives

5 · Subjunctive & unreal past

6 · Cleft sentences & emphasis

7 · Participle & absolute clauses

8 · Advanced & impersonal passive

9 · Advanced modality

10 · Formal connectors & register

SECTION 1

The conditional system

Zero conditional

If + present simple, ... present simple

General truths, scientific facts and habits — the condition always has the same result.

- " If you heat water to 100°C, it boils.
- " If the alarm goes off, everyone leaves the building.

First conditional

If + present, ... will / can / may / imperative

A real, likely possibility in the future and its result.

- " If we leave now, we'll catch the early train.
- " If you see Anna, tell her to call me.

Second conditional

If + past simple, ... would / could / might + inf.

An unreal or unlikely present/future situation and its imagined result.

- " If I had more time, I'd learn the piano.
- " If I were you, I'd apologise straight away.

Third conditional

If + past perfect, ... would have + p.p.

An unreal past — the opposite of what really happened; often regret or criticism.

- " If she had revised, she would have passed.
- " If we'd left earlier, we wouldn't have missed the flight.

Mixed conditional — past → present

If + past perfect, ... would + inf. (now)

A past condition with a present result.

- " If I had accepted that job, I'd be living in London now.
- " If they hadn't sold the house, they'd still be neighbours.

Mixed conditional — present → past

If + past simple, ... would have + p.p.

A present/general (unchanging) condition with a past result.

- " If he weren't so careless, he wouldn't have lost the keys.
- " If I spoke Japanese, I'd have taken that posting last year.

SECTION 2

Beyond "if": conditional alternatives

unless

"If ... not / except if." Introduces the only thing that would change the result.

- " You won't pass unless you revise. (= *if you don't revise*)
- " I'll be there by six unless the train is delayed.

provided / providing (that) • as long as • on condition that

A strong condition — "only if this is true." *On condition that* is the most formal.

- " I'll lend it to you provided (that) you return it by Friday.
- " He was released on condition that he report to the police weekly.

supposing / suppose • what if spoken

Introduces a hypothesis, usually in conversation; often followed by a second conditional.

- " Supposing you lost your job, what would you do?
- " What if we're wrong about him?

in case

A precaution: you do X *because* Y might happen — not the same as *if*.

- " Take an umbrella in case it rains. (*take it now, as a precaution*)
- " I'll write it down in case I forget.

otherwise / or (else)

"If not / if you don't" — states the negative consequence.

- " Write it down; otherwise you'll forget.
- " We must leave now, or else we'll be late.

but for • if it weren't / hadn't been for formal

"Without (this), the result would be different." *But for* is followed by a noun.

- " But for your help, I'd have failed. (= *if it hadn't been for your help*)
- " If it weren't for the noise, this flat would be perfect.

even if

The result stays the same whether or not the condition is true (concession).

- " Even if we ran, we wouldn't make it now.
- " I wouldn't sign it even if they doubled the offer.

SECTION 3

Conditional inversion (formal, without "if")

Were + subject **formal**

Were + S (...), ... would + inf.

Formal equivalent of the **second** conditional; drop *if* and put *were* first.

" Were I in your position, I'd resign. (= *If I were...*)

" Were she a little older, she'd understand.

Were + subject + to-infinitive **formal**

Were + S + to-inf., ... would + inf.

A hypothetical future possibility — common in careful or diplomatic writing.

" Were the government to fall, elections would follow.

" Were you to reconsider, we'd gladly welcome you back.

Were it not for + noun **formal**

Present "without." Inverted form of *if it weren't for*.

" Were it not for your support, I'd give up. (= *If it weren't for...*)

Had + subject + past participle **formal**

Had + S + p.p., ... would have + p.p.

Formal equivalent of the **third** conditional; drop *if* and put *had* first.

" Had I known, I would have told you. (= *If I had known...*)

" Had they invested sooner, they'd have doubled their money.

Had it not been for + noun **formal**

Past "without." Inverted form of *if it hadn't been for*.

" Had it not been for the storm, we'd have arrived on time.

Should + subject **formal**

Should + S + inf., ... (imperative / will)

A formal **first** conditional suggesting the event is possible but not expected — common in correspondence and instructions.

" Should you require assistance, please call reception. (= *If you (should) need...*)

" Should anything go wrong, contact us immediately.

SECTION 4

Inversion after negative & limiting adverbials

Never / Not once / At no time

Negative adverbial + auxiliary + S + verb

Front a negative adverbial for emphasis and invert like a question.

" Never had I seen such chaos.

" Not once did she complain.

Rarely / Seldom / Little

Little is fixed with verbs of knowing/realising (= not at all).

" Seldom do we see such talent.

" Little did they know what awaited them.

Hardly / Scarcely ... when • No sooner ... than

Two things happening in quick succession. Note *when* vs *than*; both use inversion + past perfect.

" Hardly had we sat down when the phone rang.

" No sooner had I left than it started to rain.

Not only ... but (also)

Adds a second, stronger point; invert after *not only*.

" Not only did he lie, but he also blamed his colleague.

" Not only is she brilliant, she's also generous.

Not until / Only when / Only after / Only then

Inversion falls on the **main** clause, not the time clause.

" Not until midnight did they finish.

" Only when the lights came on did we realise the danger.

Only by / Only in this way

Emphasises the sole means of achieving something.

" Only by working together can we succeed.

" Only in this way will the problem be solved.

Under no circumstances / On no account **formal**

A strong prohibition; often paired with *be to* or a modal.

" Under no circumstances are you to open that door.

" On no account should the documents be copied.

So + adj. ... (that) • Such ... (that)

Front *so* + adjective or *such* + noun for dramatic emphasis.

" So great was the demand that tickets sold out in minutes.

" Such was her charm that everyone forgave her.

SECTION 5

The subjunctive & the unreal past

Mandative (present) subjunctive formal

suggest / insist / demand / recommend / propose / essential + that + S + base form

The **base form** for every person (no -s, no *was/is*); negative = *not* + base.

- " The board recommended that he resign.
- " It is essential that every member be present, and that latecomers not be admitted.

"should" alternative BrE

British English often uses *should* + base form for the same meaning — slightly less formal.

- " The board recommended that he should resign.
- " I insist that you should be told the truth.

were-subjunctive (unreal)

Use *were* for all persons after *if*, *wish*, *as if/as though*, *suppose*, *would rather*.

- " If I were you... / She talks as if she were the boss.
- " I wish it were Friday.

wish / if only + past

Regret about the **present**. *If only* is more emphatic than *wish*.

- " I wish I knew the answer.
- " If only he were here now.

wish / if only + past perfect

Regret about the **past** — something you can no longer change.

- " I wish I had listened to your advice.
- " If only we hadn't sold the flat.

wish + would

Annoyance or a desire for change in *someone else's* behaviour (not your own).

- " I wish you would stop interrupting.
- " I wish it would stop raining.

It's (high / about) time + past

Says something is overdue; the past form has present meaning.

- " It's high time we left.
- " It's about time you learned to drive.

would rather / would sooner + past

Preference about *another person's* action; use a past form for present/future.

- " I'd rather you didn't smoke in here.
- " She'd sooner we came on Sunday.

Fixed subjunctive expressions literary

Survivals of the subjunctive kept as set phrases.

- " Be that as it may... / Come what may... / So be it.
- " Suffice (it) to say... / Far be it from me to criticise... / Long live the King.

lest literary

"In order that ... not / for fear that," followed by a subjunctive or *should*.

- " He spoke quietly lest he wake the baby.
- " They kept watch lest anyone should escape.

SECTION 6

Cleft sentences & emphasis

It-cleft It + be + focus + who / that ...

Splits a sentence to spotlight one element (person, thing, time, reason).

- " It was Maria who solved the problem. (*not anyone else*)
- " It wasn't until 1990 that the truth emerged.

Wh-cleft (pseudo-cleft) What + clause + be + focus

Fronts a *what*-clause to emphasise an action or thing.

- " What I need is a proper holiday.
- " What she did was (to) resign on the spot.

The thing / reason / place ... is

A flexible cleft using a general noun as the launch-pad.

- " The reason (why) I called is to apologise.
- " The thing that annoys me is the waste.

All (that) ... is

Means "the only thing"; downplays or limits.

- " All I want is a quiet life.
- " All you have to do is sign here.

Fronting for emphasis

Move an object or complement to the front for contrast or drama.

- " That kind of rudeness I simply won't tolerate.
- " Really impressive, the whole performance was.

Emphatic do / does / did

Add the auxiliary to stress a positive verb or to contradict.

- " I do apologise for the delay.
- " She did warn you — you just didn't listen.

SECTION 7

Participle & absolute clauses

Present participle (-ing) clause

Same subject as the main clause; expresses time, reason or a simultaneous action.

- " Feeling tired, she went straight to bed.
- " Living abroad, he rarely sees his family.

Perfect participle (Having + p.p.)

Shows the first action is clearly completed before the second.

- " Having finished the report, he logged off.
- " Having lived there for years, she knew every street.

Past participle (-ed) clause

Has a passive meaning (= *because/if it is/was ...*).

- " Shocked by the news, they fell silent.
- " If treated early, the condition is curable.

Absolute construction **formal**

noun + participle, ... main clause

A clause with its *own* subject and no conjunction — very formal/written.

- " The weather being fine, we set off at dawn.
- " Her work finished, she headed home.

Fixed absolute phrases

Common set expressions built on the same pattern.

- " All things considered, it went well. / Weather permitting, we'll walk.
- " That said, I take your point. / Present company excepted.

Reduced relative clause

A participle replaces *who/which + be*, tightening the sentence.

- " The man standing by the door... (= *who is standing*)
- " Documents signed today take effect at once. (= *that are signed*)

SECTION 8

The advanced & impersonal passive

Reporting-verb passive (personal) **formal**

S + be + said / believed / thought + to-inf. / to have + p.p.

Reports opinion or rumour impersonally; use *to have + p.p.* for earlier time.

- " He is said to be extremely wealthy.
- " She is believed to have left the country.

Impersonal "It is ... that" **formal**

The other way to report a general view — common in news and academic writing.

- " It is thought that the talks will resume shortly.
- " It was once believed that the earth was flat.

Causative: have something done

have + object + past participle

You arrange for someone else to do a service for you.

- " We're having the kitchen renovated.
- " You should have your eyes tested.

Experiential have / get something done

Describes something (often unpleasant) that happened to you. *Get* is more informal.

- " He had his wallet stolen on the train.
- " I got my hair cut yesterday.

need / want + -ing **BrE**

A passive meaning without a passive form (= needs to be done).

- " The car needs washing.
- " This shirt wants ironing.

get-passive **spoken**

An informal alternative to the *be*-passive, often for sudden or unwelcome events.

- " She got promoted last month.
- " He got caught cheating.

SECTION 9

Advanced modality

must / can't (couldn't) have + p.p.

Near-certain deduction about the **past**: *must* = surely true, *can't* = surely false.

- " She must have left already — her coat's gone.
- " He can't have known; nobody told him.

might / may / could have + p.p.

Past possibility — one option among several.

- " They might have missed the turning.
- " It could have been worse.

should / ought to have + p.p.

An expectation that wasn't met — criticism or regret.

- " You should have told me sooner.
- " I ought to have known better.

needn't have vs didn't need to

Needn't have + p.p. = you did it but it was unnecessary; *didn't need to* = it wasn't necessary (often not done).

- " You needn't have paid — it was free. (*but you did pay*)
- " I didn't need to pay, so I kept the cash.

would / used to (past habits)

Repeated past actions. Use *used to* (not *would*) for past **states**.

- " As a boy he would spend hours reading.
- " We used to live by the sea. (*state — not "would live"*)

will / would (characteristic behaviour)

Typical or predictable behaviour; stressed *will/would* shows irritation.

- " She'll sit there reading for hours.
- " He would leave the door open, wouldn't he!

may / might (very) well · may as well

May well = quite likely; *may/might as well* = there's no better option.

- " You may well be right.
- " We might as well walk — it's quicker than waiting.

SECTION 10

Formal connectors & register

Concession: albeit · notwithstanding · much as · granted **formal**

Formal ways to say "although." *Albeit* introduces a phrase, not a full clause.

- " The plan, albeit costly, is sound.
- " Much as I admire her, I can't agree. / Notwithstanding the delay, we finished.

whilst · whereas **BrE**

Whilst is a formal BrE variant of *while*; *whereas* marks direct contrast.

- " Whilst I understand your concern, the rules are clear.
- " He is cautious, whereas she takes risks.

Consequence: hence · thus · thereby · accordingly **formal**

Formal links of result. *Thereby* + *-ing* shows a resulting effect.

- " He missed the deadline; hence the penalty.
- " She signed early, thereby avoiding the queue.

whereby · insofar as · thereof · hereby **formal**

Legal/official connectors: *whereby* = by which; *insofar as* = to the extent that.

- " a scheme whereby costs are shared.
- " insofar as the law allows / I hereby declare the meeting open.

be to + infinitive **formal**

Official future plans, instructions or orders — common in news and rules.

- " The Prime Minister is to visit Rome next week.
- " Staff are to report to reception on arrival.

Register shifts: neutral → formal

Swap everyday words for their formal equivalents in essays and letters.

- " get → obtain/receive · ask for → request · need → require · enough → sufficient.
- " but → however · also → moreover/furthermore · so → therefore · a lot of → a great deal of.